UNIVERSITY OF THE WITWATERSRAND, JOHANNESBURG | WSoE Wits School of Education

WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 4 · 12 November 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

This fortnight the debate moved from whether students use AI to how well they use it: new studies from Australia, South Africa and Nigeria agree that habit and depth of engagement, not mere access or policy wording, are what predict better learning and better graduate prospects. Institutions are responding unevenly, some reaching for in-person exams and stricter policies on cheating, others, including Wits with its new Global Higher Education Futures Centre, choosing to build the pedagogy and the research capacity instead. Statistics South Africa's third-quarter figures remind us why this matters here: youth unemployment eased only slightly to 47.3%, so the return on every hour of study still has to be earned. For Wits AHEAD, the task stays the same: helping graduates turn capability, not just access, into opportunity.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 11 NOVEMBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

Office for Students tells universities to bring back in-person exams to protect assessment from AI

England's Office for Students has told universities to consider returning to in-person, closed-book exams, vivas and practical tasks to keep assessment valid as artificial intelligence spreads. The guidance follows a four-month study with Advance HE, based on conversations with around 300 students and staff at more than 120 institutions, which found AI use is widespread and that some assessments are not fit for purpose. It is the first time the regulator has set out the institutional AI practices that could trigger intervention, including a lower quality award.

> **Why it matters:** Wits AHEAD's first pillar is generative AI in higher education, including assessment and integrity; a national regulator moving from guidance to enforceable consequences is a marker other systems, including South Africa's, are likely to watch.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · **Read at source**

Luckhurst, G. (2026, November 11). OfS pushes in-person exams to 'protect sector's reputation'. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/ofs-pushes-person-exams-protect-sectors-reputation

2

REPORT · 11 NOVEMBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

Graduates' wellbeing and civic contribution should be tracked alongside pay, British Academy argues

The British Academy says current measures of graduate success focus too narrowly on salary, and wants work-life balance, long-term health and civic engagement tracked as well. It points to a government survey finding 24% of graduates volunteer formally at least monthly, against 17% of non-graduates, and proposes linking higher education data with health and crime datasets to build a fuller picture.

> **Why it matters:** Wits AHEAD's fourth pillar covers graduate capability and employability beyond the first job; a national academy's push for broader outcome measures speaks directly to how the group frames "success" for its own candidates.

British Academy, reported by Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · **Read at source**

Luckhurst, G. (2026, November 11). Graduates' work-life balance 'should be tracked alongside pay'. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/graduates-work-life-balance-should-be-tracked-alongside-pay

3

REPORT · 10 NOVEMBER 2026 · SOUTH AFRICA

Youth unemployment eases slightly to 47.3% as overall unemployment rises to 33.7% in the third quarter of 2026

The official unemployment rate rose by 0.1 of a percentage point to 33.7% in Q3 2026, as employment grew by 101,000 to 16.8 million but the labour force grew faster still. Youth unemployment (15 to 34) eased by 0.1 of a percentage point to 47.3%: unemployed youth fell by 23,000 to 5.0 million, while employed youth fell by 5,000 to 5.5 million.

> **Why it matters:** This is the figure the group uses for graduate pathways and just transitions. Pillar 4 asks whether AI is narrowing or widening this gap for exactly this cohort.

Statistics South Africa · statssa.gov.za · **Read at source**

Statistics South Africa. (2026, November 10). *Quarterly Labour Force Survey (QLFS): Q3 2026* [Press release]. statssa.gov.za/publications/P0211/Media%20Release%20QLFS%20Q3%202026.pdf

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Wits opens a Global Higher Education Futures Centre, with a dedicated generative AI pedagogy hub

University of the Witwatersrand · 9 November 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. For pillar 6, a South African university is building its own framework for thinking about AI's disruption of higher education, rather than adopting one designed elsewhere, which is exactly the Global South-led, equity-centred approach Wits AHEAD exists to support.

University of the Witwatersrand. (2026, November 9). Wits launches the Global Higher Education Futures Centre. wits.ac.za/news/latest-news/research-news/2026/2026-11/wits-launches-the-global-higher-education-futures-centre.html

AI-generated 'slop' papers published under prominent academics' names without their consent

Times Higher Education · 9 November 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. For pillar 6, the episode shows how generative AI can be used to fabricate not just research findings but researchers' own identities, which is why responsible AI policy for higher education must extend to publishing integrity and not stop at the classroom.

Asaf, S. (2026, November 9). 'AI slop' papers published under prominent academics' names. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/ai-slop-papers-published-under-prominent-academics-names

Wording of university generative AI policies shapes how students and teachers actually behave, study finds

arXiv preprint (University of Maryland and University of Iowa researchers) · 8 November 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For pillar 1, the study is a reminder that a generative AI policy is only as good as its wording: universities writing or revising their own rules on AI in teaching and assessment need to test not just what a rule permits, but how students and staff will read and act on the words themselves.

Mehreen, S., Yuan, X., Nithyanand, R., & Hoque, N. (2026). *Wording matters: Understanding how GenAI policy rules shape teachers' and students' workflows and perceptions*. arXiv. arxiv.org/abs/2611.11072

How deeply students engage with an AI chat, not how often they use it, predicts better coursework, large Australian study finds

University of Queensland and Monash University (arXiv preprint, submitted to the Journal of Computer Assisted Learning) · 8 November 2026 · Pillar 2: Analytics for student success. For pillar 2, the finding matters for any institution building analytics around AI tool use: counting how often students open a chatbot tells you little about learning, so systems meant to support student success need to look at the depth of engagement, not the frequency of clicks.

Zhuang, X., Bakharia, A., Gašević, D., & Khosravi, H. (2026). *From dialogue to task: How cognitive engagement with generative artificial intelligence relates to post-dialogue activity and task outcomes*. arXiv. arxiv.org/abs/2611.11435

WATCH

▶ World Bank video: 'small AI', not big models alone, can widen opportunity in developing-economy education and jobs (1 hr 16 min)

World Bank Group (YouTube). At the Global AI and Digital Summit in Seoul, recorded by the World Bank Group, President Ajay Banga opened a panel on how practical, locally adapted "small AI" tools, not only large general-purpose models, can expand opportunity in developing economies. Nigeria's Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy Bosun Tijani joined Tridge chief executive Hoshik Shin and Amini founder Kate Kallot to discuss education, agriculture and public services, including a segment on lessons from using AI in education in El Salvador. The panel named reliable local data, affordable connectivity, computing power, skills and procurement systems as the conditions that let local innovators scale AI solutions.

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 **Partnerships: Australia joins the Footprint map, collaboration with Murdoch University, Perth, developing**
Exploring joint work on AI and education between Wits and Murdoch; memorandum of understanding in preparation.

12 Sep 2026 **Masters research report completed with distinction; candidate to graduate in December 2026**
A bibliometric review of data-driven leadership and policy design; the candidate now moves to a doctoral proposal.

12 Sep 2026 **Doctoral thesis completed; candidate to graduate in December 2026**
Examiner-required corrections accepted on a study of highly successful distance-learning students in East African higher education.

A READING WE PROFFER

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). The H in AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,

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